

All In: A Public Services Philosophy for the Twenty-First Century Academic Library

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If one were to ask any academic library dean or director if service to users was a priority, no doubt each of them would say yes. After all, academic libraries have long focused on offering support to those engaged in the academic enterprise. Over time, the services have changed, but the need for them has only continued to grow. No longer merely an academic support unit, the library is a partner to faculty, staff, students, and community users and is core to the university's mission. Its work aligns with institutional strategic plans that emphasize teaching and learning, faculty scholarship, student success, informed citizenship, and global awareness. The ability to discover, evaluate, and use information and to create new knowledge in these areas is key to realizing the university's goals, and a dynamic array of public services is integral to the process.

The term "public services" once had a common meaning and described a simple slate of patron services, but outward-facing offerings have evolved significantly since.¹ Services that formerly centered around a reference or public desk have become vibrant interactions that involve teaching and expert consultation, use of content across diverse formats, innovative technologies, flexible learning spaces, and relationships that span a spectrum of creativity and collaboration. As academic libraries have evolved, so too have their organizational frameworks. While the term "public services" is still meaningful and in use, public services as an organizational construct is increasingly absorbed into other structural forms and nomenclature such as Digital Initiatives, Liaison Support, and Scholarly Communication. In fact, one might argue that the new and differentiated services that have emerged have rendered the term "public services" obsolete. The conversation might more usefully focus on identifying gaps in service and responsibility, exploring how the public service endeavor is presented to the academic community, and ensuring that professional standards and values are firmly established and met.

If that is the case, it is less important for all functions to reside under one umbrella responsible for public services and more crucial that the organization as a whole em-



brace a unified public service philosophy. In concert with that philosophy, professionals must employ a common body of knowledge, values, and standards to ensure that the services they provide meet the information needs of the community they serve. In the end, the issue is not whether Access Services reports to a head of public services or a director for library systems; instead, the issue is whether both those areas—and all others—have the same priorities and uphold the same vision, focusing on and engaging with users. Catalogers, facilities managers, and information technology (IT) staff—not just members of outward-facing departments—must be familiar with the needs of their constituents and committed to serving them. At a time when libraries find themselves in fierce competition for a market share of information consumers, cultivating this organizational understanding is critical to libraries' success. It is all about the library in the life of the user—not the user in the life of the library.² For some libraries, this approach comes naturally; for others, it is more of a struggle, if not a completely foreign concept.

This special issue of *portal: Libraries and the Academy* explores the need for a pervasive public services and user engagement philosophy in the twenty-first century academic library. The genesis of this project was a discussion about the role and status of public services in the contemporary academic library and whether those services were waning or thriving. Neither description seemed wholly accurate, despite the certainty that all academic library effort should revolve around a commitment to the user. A preliminary look at the literature established that many institutions were rethinking service strategies,³ though little had been written about the definition or impact of this new public services construct. The discussion led to more questions, which the editors eventually posed to prospective authors in an invitation to consider ways that the commitment to services is being articulated and accomplished as libraries reimagine themselves and their services.⁴ The content that resulted, thought-provoking and diverse, reflects a broad interpretation of what a public services agenda might encompass in the transformative academic library.

Accomplishing any agenda begins and ends with the people involved. Diane Dallis's interviews of a small group of library leaders shed light on common themes and insights about the current state of academic libraries and librarianship, exploring the importance of the master of library science degree and new positions emerging in public services areas. Brian Keith, Bonnie Smith, and Laurie Taylor explain the history and purpose of the Association of Research Libraries (ARL) Position Description (PD) Bank, which "provides a source for current PDs and also tracks the evolution of positions—and library functions and services—and the varied ways in which institutions organize and define functions."⁵

Exploring the vocabulary of public services, Allison Benedetti poses the question of whether we are employing understandable, user-centered language when marketing our services. After conducting focus groups with faculty and students at the University of California, Los Angeles, she learned that different terminology resonates with different audiences. Her commonsense recommendations include dropping outdated terms such as "reference desk" and avoiding historical stereotypes and assumptions while keeping in mind that the most important thing is that users know what we do.

Library services that have typically fallen within the rubric of public services include instruction. Lorelei Rutledge and Sarah LeMire examine ways that academic librarians



are broadening their conceptualization of information literacy (IL), sharing examples of where it is successfully integrated into curricula, scaling IL with micro-teaching opportunities, employing social and participatory learning, and creating spaces to support personalized learning environments. Juan Carlos Rodriguez, Kristin Meyer, and Brian Merry describe a shift in their Access Services department's philosophy from library-centric to user-centric to better respond to patron needs. Focusing on the relationship aspect inherent in successful service provision, Jennifer Church-Duran shares strategies libraries employ to strengthen teaching, outreach, and engagement efforts through restructured liaison roles and models. She concludes that engaged librarianship needs to be connected to organizational strategy, structure, and culture to be most impactful and to effect innovation. José Díaz and Meris Mandernach investigate qualities that help faculty-librarian relationships succeed and report on findings of liaison librarian and faculty focus groups. Fostering personal relationships, finding mutual benefit, and sharing responsibility are key components to success.

The notion of collections as service is critical to the success of today's academic library. To that end, Doug Way outlines a framework for transitioning monographic collections practices to a user-centric model and invites libraries to leverage technology and implement efficiencies to maximize access and "save time, money, and space." Challenging the boundaries of what libraries should collect and lend, Ryan Buller describes a project to lend video game consoles to support a game-design curriculum. Marlee Givens, Lisa Macklin, and Paolo Mangiafico review three case studies where academic libraries played a central role in developing faculty profile systems to capture researchers' scholarly outputs and activities. They probe why the expertise of librarians is a desirable commodity in realizing these university initiatives. Providing an overview of the historical and evolving challenges and opportunities of managing data collections services, Karen Hogenboom and Michele Hayslett make the case for why academic libraries can serve as a central location for assembling data despite the issues and complexity of the current data environment.

Space as service—not merely as square footage—is another fundamental element of a grounded public services philosophy. Mary Ellen Spencer and Sarah Watstein provide an overview of the ways many academic libraries develop such a view as they define attributes of student learning spaces. Ian Godfrey, Lorelei Rutledge, Alfred Mowdood, Jacob Reed, Scott Bigler, and Catherine Soehner detail their library's efforts to support student retention by adding a family area in their library to meet the needs of students with children. They discuss conceptualizing the space and their goals for it. Extolling the benefits of collaboration and partnership, Jennifer Nichols, Maggie Melo, and Jason Dewland chronicle the creation and operation of their iSpace, a makerspace designed to support digital humanities, innovation, and entrepreneurship across their campus.

Defining what success looks like and evaluating to well-established goals are essential parts of any service agenda. Devin Savage, Pattie Piotrowski, and Lisa Massengale examine how libraries use tools to assess their services, spaces, and collections. They determine that assessment happens at multiple levels, suggesting both challenges and opportunities for the future.

These 15 articles provide something of a playbook for developing an all-encompassing public services agenda and incorporating it into the academic library enterprise.



They invite academic libraries to examine existing frameworks and to consider expansive approaches in defining and infusing user-centric emphases throughout the multifaceted workings of their organizations. Doing so will allow libraries to have broader impact within their institutions, to influence strategic directions and accomplishments, and to contribute more fully to student achievement and faculty success. But most fundamentally, embracing a holistic public services philosophy will demonstrate that engaging the user is the library's top priority.

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Notes

1. As noted in *portal: Libraries and the Academy* 17, 1 (January 2017) announcing this special issue, "For decades, academic libraries typically employed a simple internal framework that categorized their efforts as either public services or technical services. As libraries have become more complex organizations, their structures have been altered to reflect this change. It now is common to see major organizational units called, for example, Access Services, Information Technology, Liaison Support, Planning and Administration, and Scholarly Communication. Within such structures, where does responsibility for public services now reside, and how will its vitality be ensured?"
2. Research and a report by the Online Computer Library Center (OCLC) have been credited with popularizing the use of this phrase. See Lynn Silipigni Connaway, comp., *The Library in the Life of the User: Engaging with People Where They Live and Learn* (Dublin, Ohio: OCLC Research, 2015), <http://www.oclc.org/content/dam/research/publications/2015/oclcresearch-library-in-life-of-user.pdf>.
3. For just a few examples of libraries rethinking their approaches to user services, see Caroline M. Kent, "Rethinking Public Services at Harvard College Library: A Case Study of Coordinated Decentralization," <http://www.ala.org/acrl/publications/booksanddigitalresources/booksmonographs/pil/pil49/kent>; David W. Lewis, "A Strategy for Academic Libraries in the First Quarter of the 21st Century," *College & Research Libraries* 68, 5 (2007): 418–34; William Miller and Rita M. Pellen, eds., "Reforming Reference," *Reference Librarian* 48, 2 (2007): 1–40; and David A. Tyckoson and John G. Dove, eds., *Reimagining Reference in the 21st Century*, Charleston Insights in Library, Archival, and Information Sciences (West Lafayette, IN: Purdue University Press, 2015). For a seminal historical perspective on services to users, see Samuel S. Green, "Personal Relations between Librarians and Readers," *Library Journal* 1, 2 (1876): 74–81.
4. The call for contributions to the special issue appeared in *portal: Libraries and the Academy* 15, 3 (July 2015).
5. Additional information about the Position Description Bank of the Association of Research Libraries (ARL) is at <http://www.arl.org/leadership-recruitment/arl-position-description-bank#.WJYfa00UWpo>; background on the project is at <https://arlpdbank.uflib.ufl.edu/docs/index.html>. It should be noted that the bank is currently a resource restricted to ARL member libraries.

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